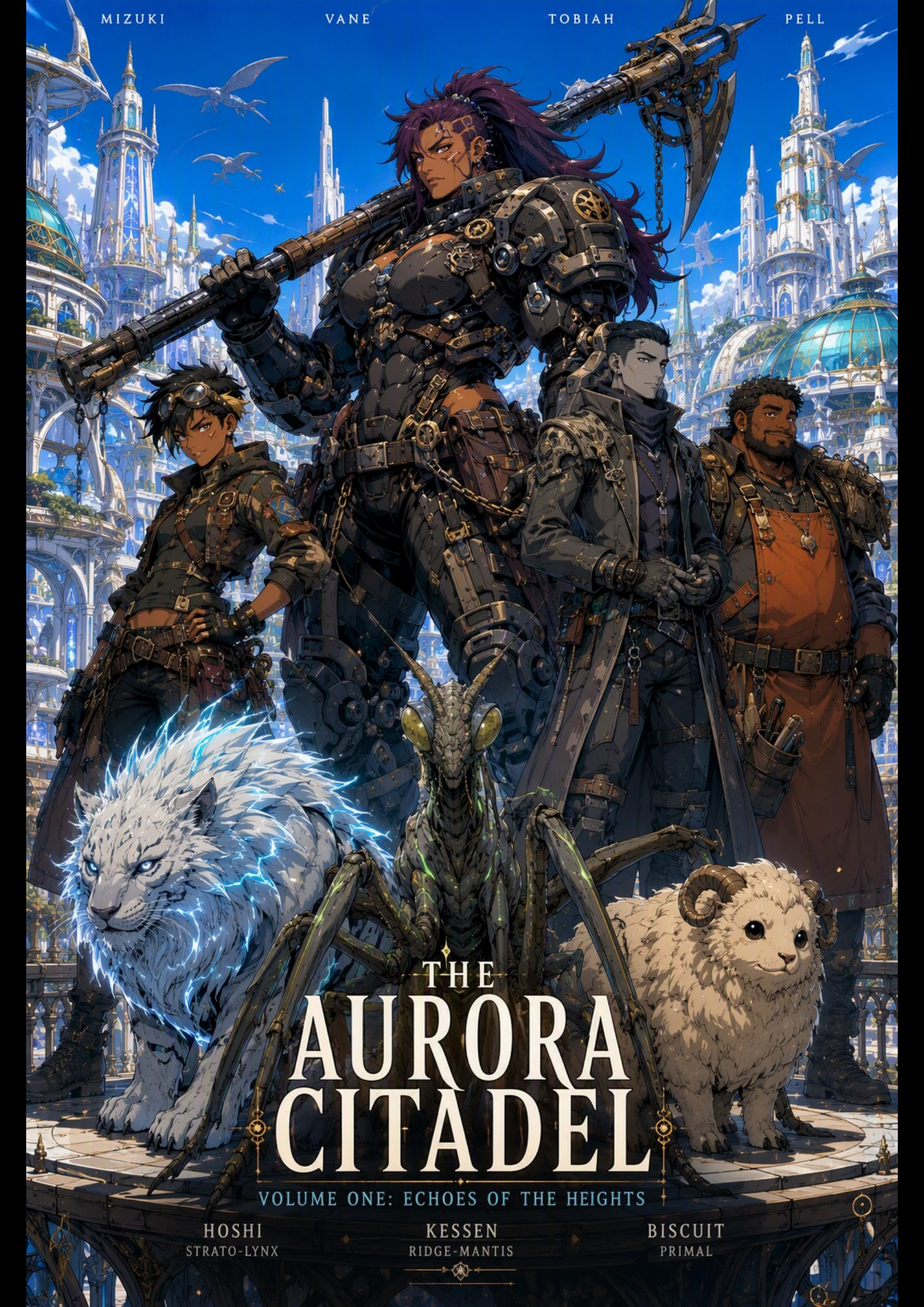


MIZUKI

VANE

TOBIAH

PELL



THE AURORA CITADEL

VOLUME ONE: ECHOES OF THE HEIGHTS

HOSHI
STRATO-LYNX

KESSEN
RIDGE-MANTIS

BISCUIT
PRIMAL

THE HIGH
MARKET OF
HALCYON ISLE.

WHERE THE
CLOUDS MEET
THE OLD ONES...

...AND EVERY
DAY IS A
BLESSING.



THANK YOU,
MIMI. THESE
WILL BE PERFECT
FOR TONIGHT'S
FEAST.



WHOOPS!

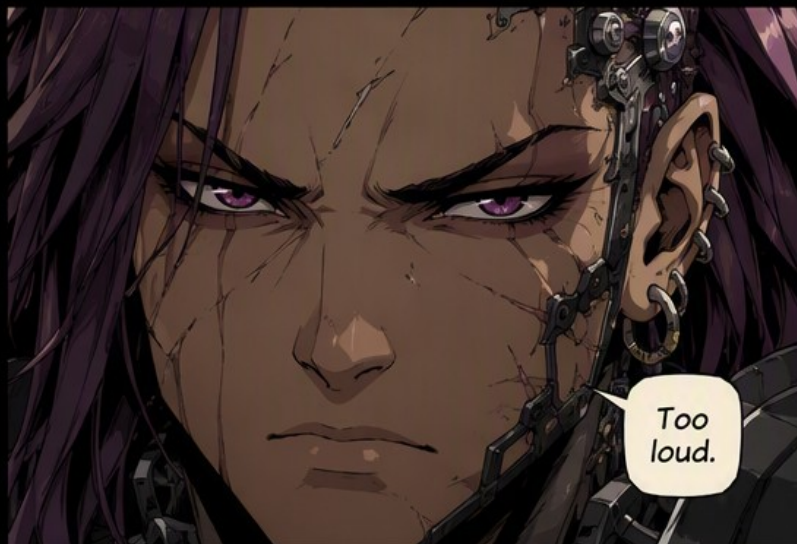
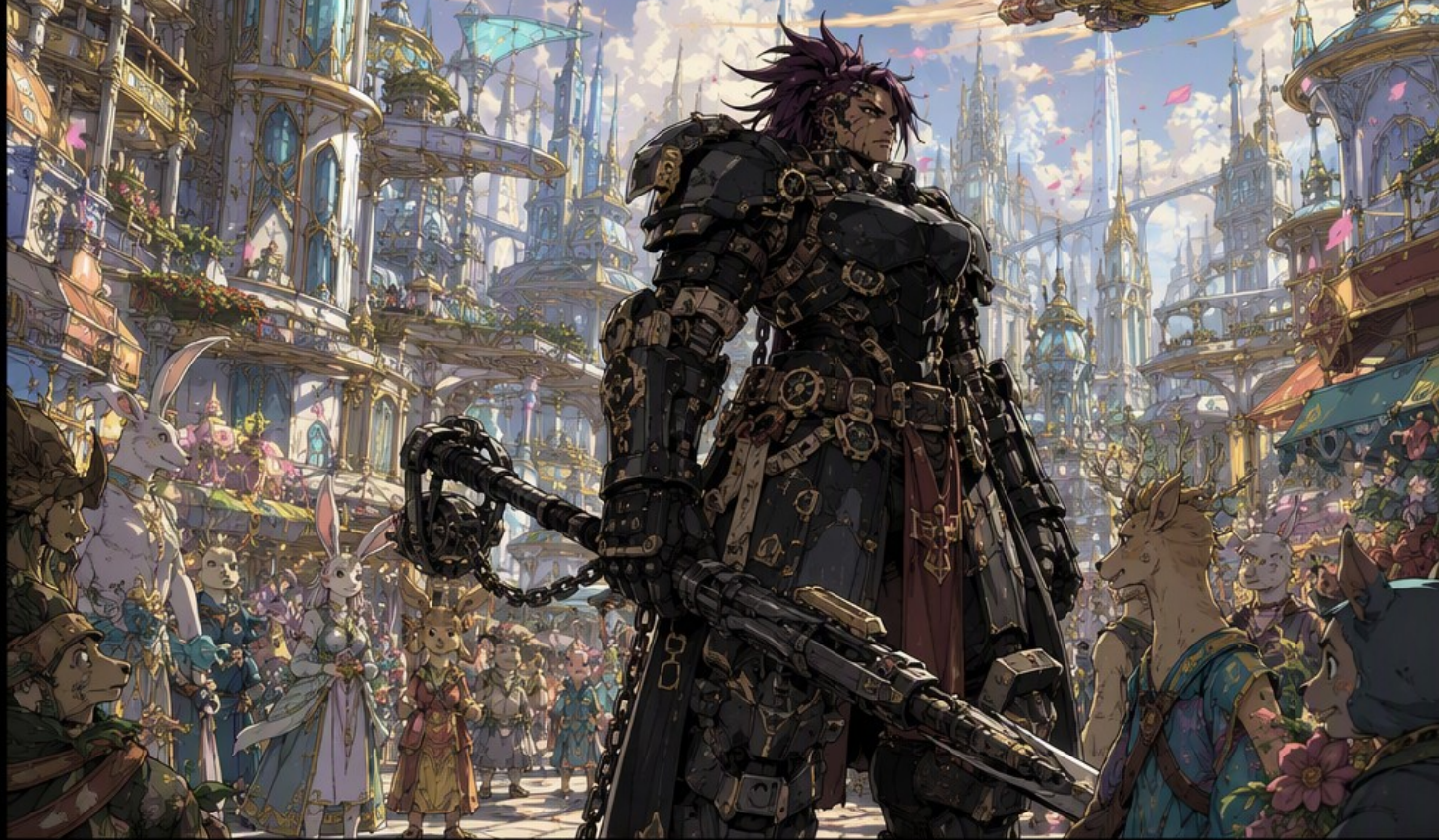
BISCUIT NEVER
TURNS DOWN
A TREAT.



ANOTHER
BEAUTIFUL DAY
IN PARADISE.

PELL
COOK. GEARSMTIH.
PROFESSIONAL
APPETITE.

WHOOOSH!!



THE AURORA CITADEL.
CROWN OF THE SKYREALM.

KEEP YOUR
PET ON A
LEASH.

CLANK!

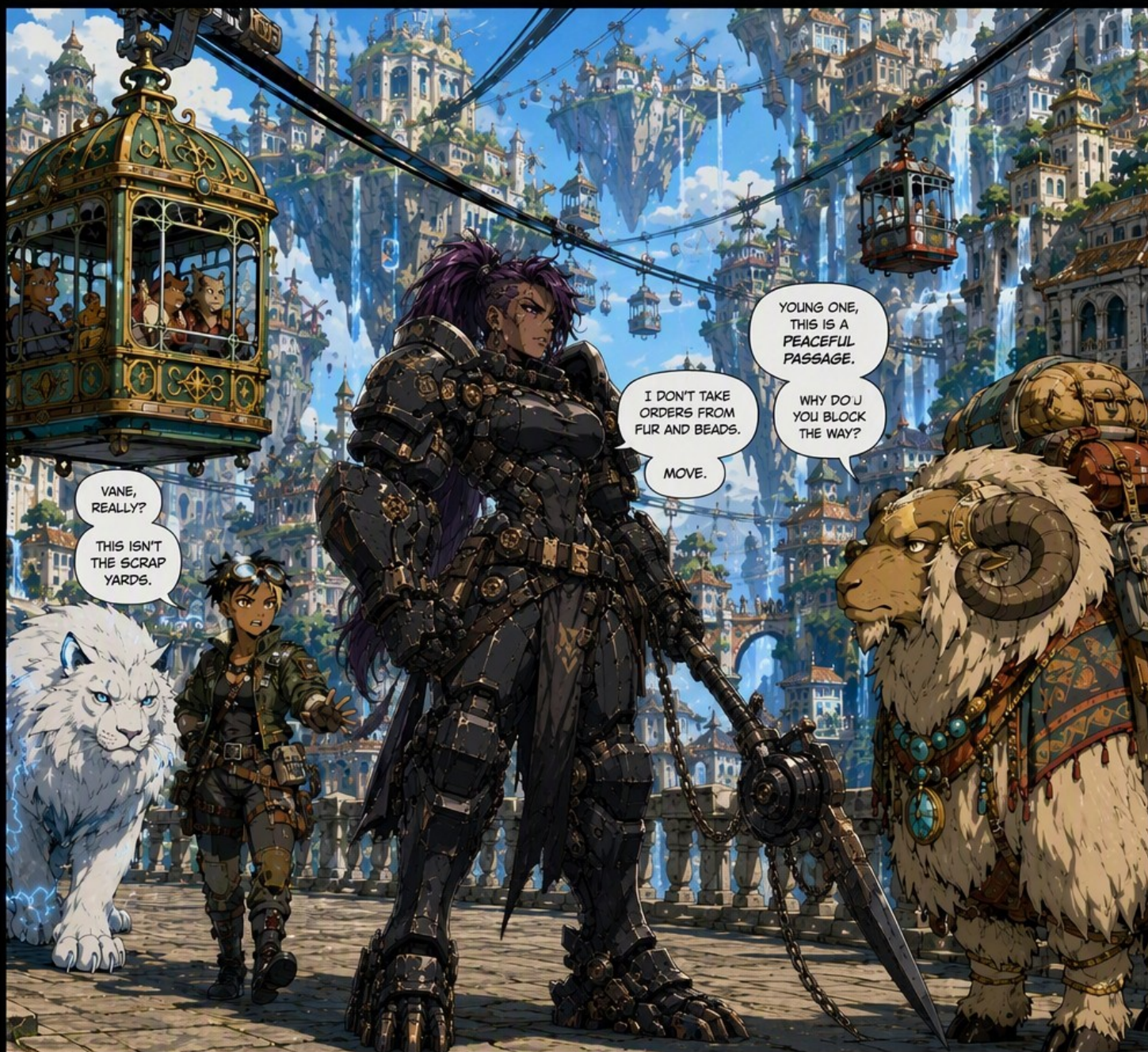
OH, FOR—
SERIOUSLY?

KEEP YOUR
PET ON A
LEASH.

HSSSSS...

CHK-CHK.

...



VANE,
REALLY?

THIS ISN'T
THE SCRAP
YARDS.

I DON'T TAKE
ORDERS FROM
FUR AND BEADS.

MOVE.

YOUNG ONE,
THIS IS A
PEACEFUL
PASSAGE.

WHY DO U
YOU BLOCK
THE WAY?



PARADISE
DON'T MEAN
NOTHING
BAD HAPPENS
HERE.

IT MEANS
EVERYONE
FOTOT HOW
TO FIGHT
BACK.



YEAH, WELL...
PICKING A FIGHT
WITH A PACK YAK
ISN'T "FIGHTING
BACK."

IT'S JUST
BEING AN
ASSHOLE.



KRRR...



HMPH.
PERHAPS.

YET STRENGTH
WITHOUT GRACE
IS STILL
WEAKNESS.



...SIGH.

LET'S JUST
GET YOU
SOMEWHERE
YOU CAN BE
MISERABLE
IN PEACE.



CANAL DISTRICT,
LUMEHOLLOW CITY
17:42 LOCAL TIME

TRADE FLOWS.
LIFE FLOWS.
IDIOTS FLOUNDER.

KESSEN
RIDGE-MANTIS
CLIFF-RUNNER
3.7m
81kg
CALM
OBSERVER



OBSERVATION:
SHE IS EXPERIENCING
AN EMOTIONAL
VULNERABILITY.

BITTER
JEALOUSY.
HOW
CHARMING.

AFTERNOON,
CITIZENS!

DELIVERIES,
DUTIES, AND
DELIGHTFUL
COMPANY!

OFFICER PEMA
CANAL WATCH
COMMUNITY LIAISON
PROFESSIONAL
MEDIATOR

REDUNDANT
ASSESSMENT.



LOOK AT THEM.

SO SMALL.
SO HAPPY.

DO THEY EVEN
KNOW THE ODDS
AGAINST THEM?



IGNORANCE
IS OFTEN AN
ADAPTIVE
ADVANTAGE.

YOU ONCE
POSSESSED
IT.



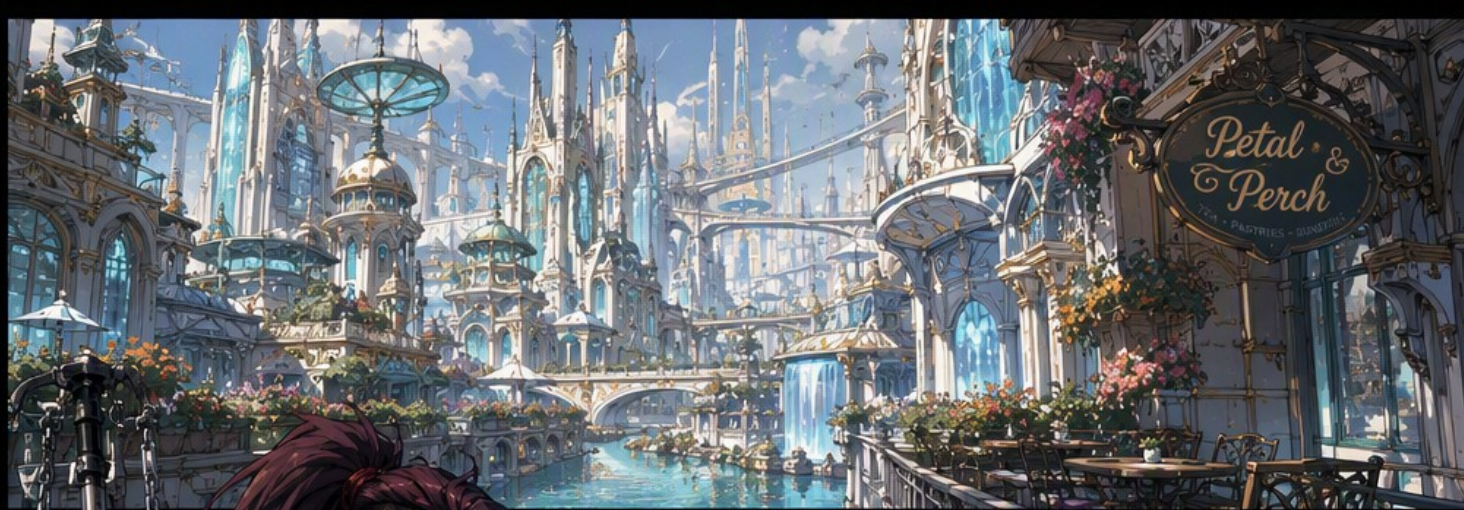
...I HAD
STANDARDS.
NOW
I HAVE
PROTOCOLS.



KESSEN
NOTE:

THE SMALL ONES
DISTRACT.

THE CURRENT
REMAINS
UNBROKEN.





CELESTIA.
CROWN OF THE
STRATUS EMPIRE.

SKREEEEEEEE-

THAT SOUND...
IT'S NOT FROM ANY
THING THAT BELONGS
IN THE SKY.



MIZUKI.

UP.
NOW.



RRRRRAA.
NOT STORM.
NOT WIND.
MACHINE.



FINALLY.
SOMETHING
WORTH MY
WEIGHT.

VANE.
VANGUARD-CLASS EXO-RIG
GRAPPLE-PIKE MODEL "EISENWA"



IN A CITY
BUILT ABOVE
THE CLOUDS...
...PERFECTION
DOESN'T BLEED.

BUT EVEN PARADISE
HAS A SOUND...
...WHEN IT'S
ABOUT TO DIE.

HIGH ABOVE
THE AURORA CITADEL...



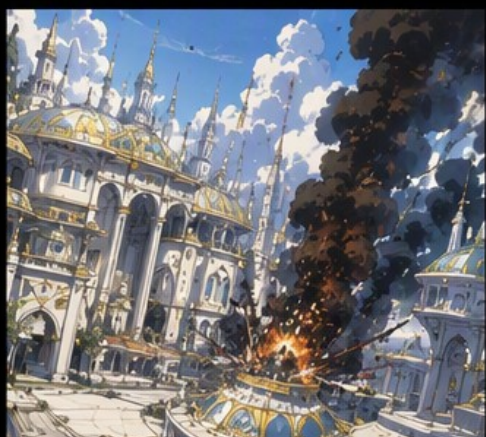
...WAR FOLLOWS
WHERE IT DOES NOT
BELONG.

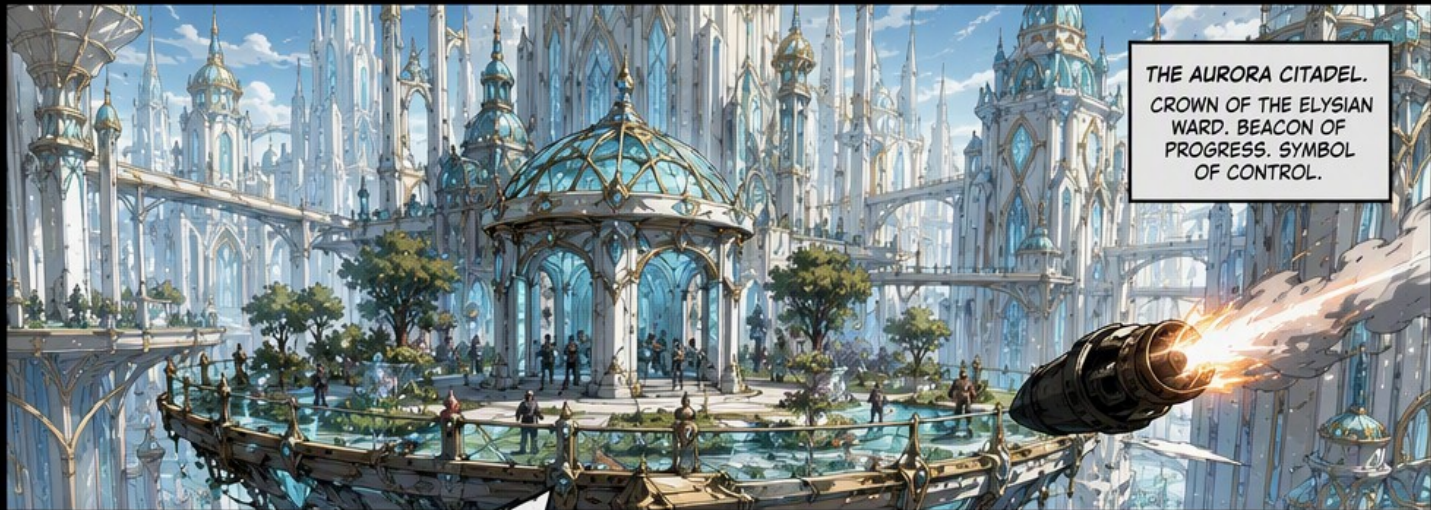


SHELL
INCOMING—!



EVERYONE
TAKE COVER!





THE AURORA CITADEL.
CROWN OF THE ELYSIAN
WARD. BEACON OF
PROGRESS. SYMBOL
OF CONTROL.



CLEAR THE
DROP ZONE!



THE AURORA CITADEL.

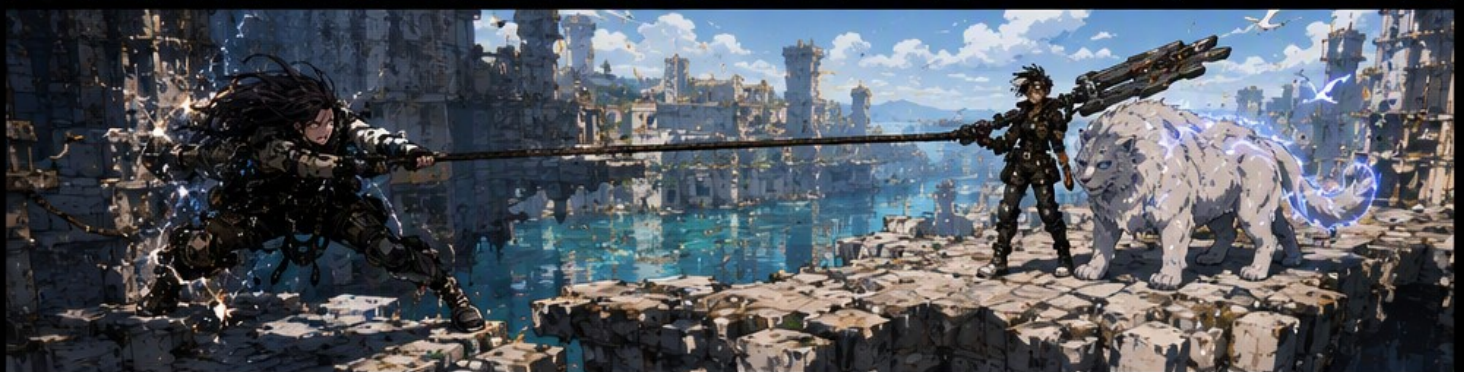
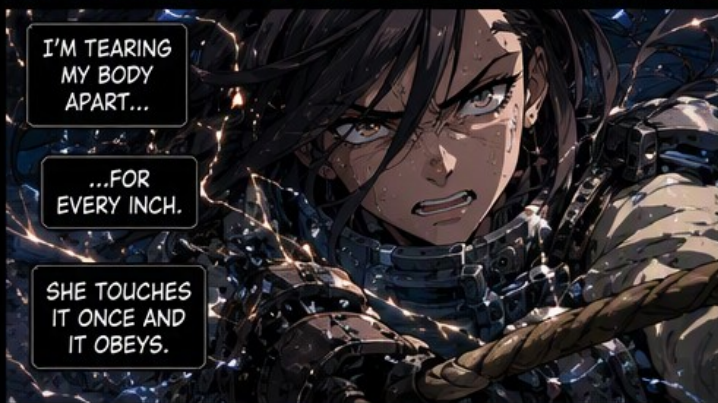
CROWN OF THE SKY.
HEART OF A THOUSAND LIGHTS.
BUILT TO INSPIRE.
DESIGNED TO ENDURE.

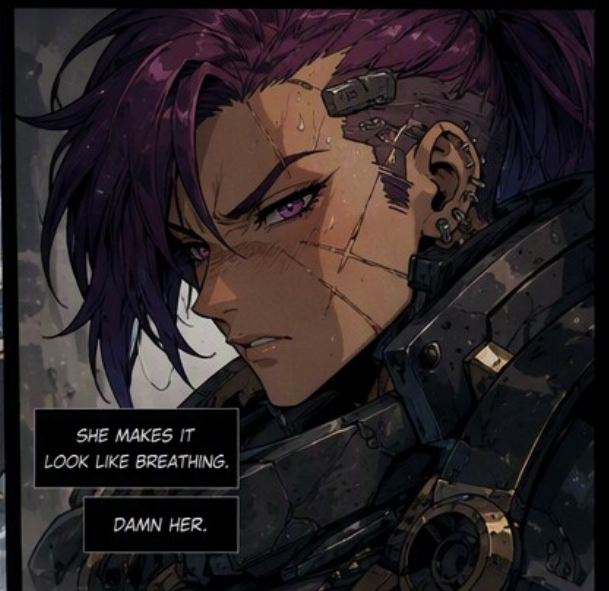
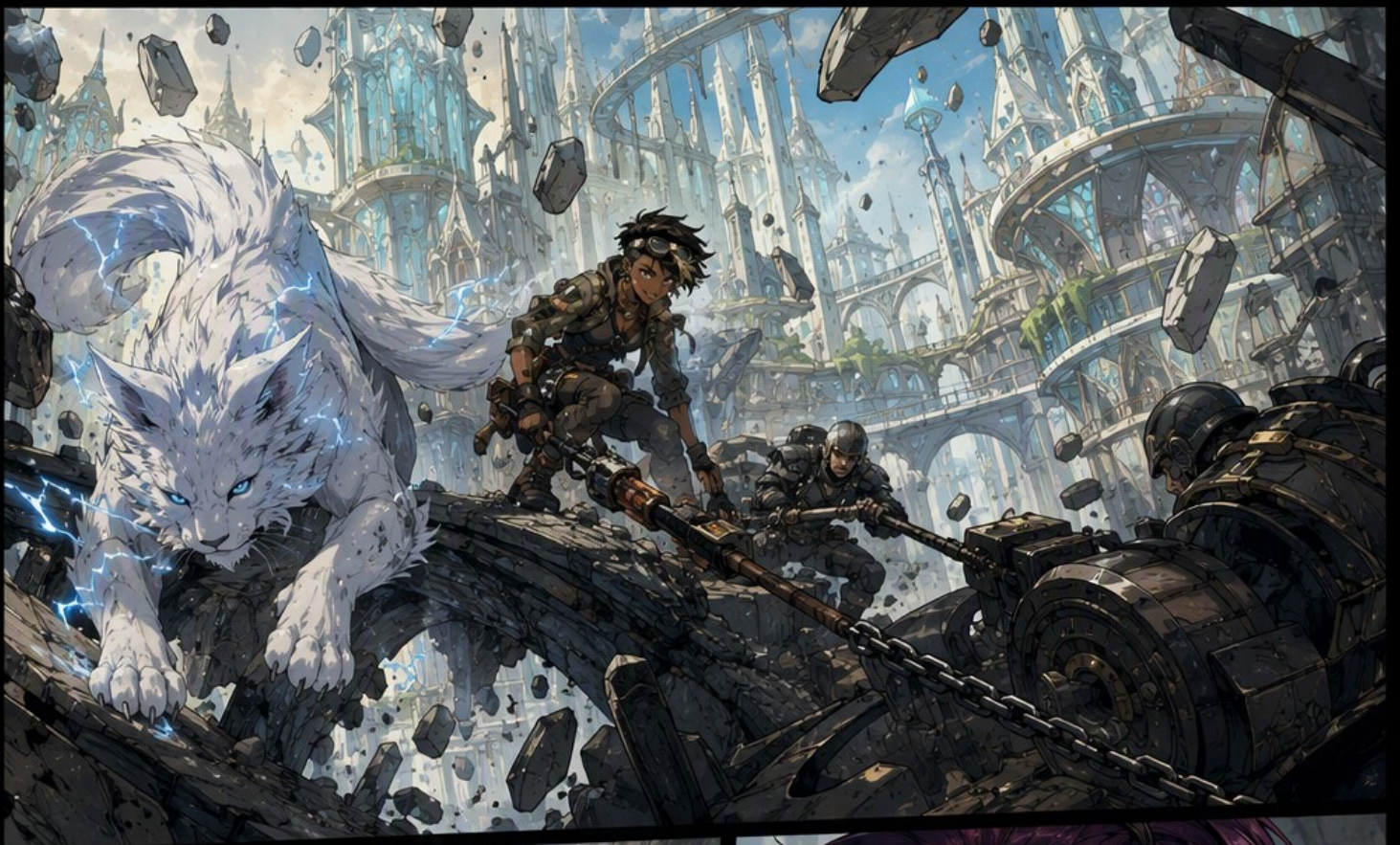
EVEN SO...
ALL THINGS FALL.

I'VE
GOT IT...
MOVE!

SKREEEEEEEE!

LOAD: 873.21%
⚠ OVERLOAD
SYSTEM STRAIN
DANGER





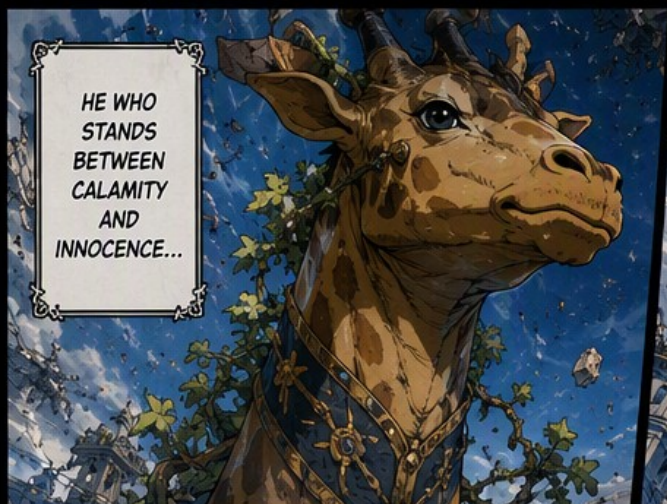


NOT
HERE.

NOT
TODAY.



IN PERFECT
CADENCE.



HE WHO
STANDS
BETWEEN
CALAMITY
AND
INNOCENCE...

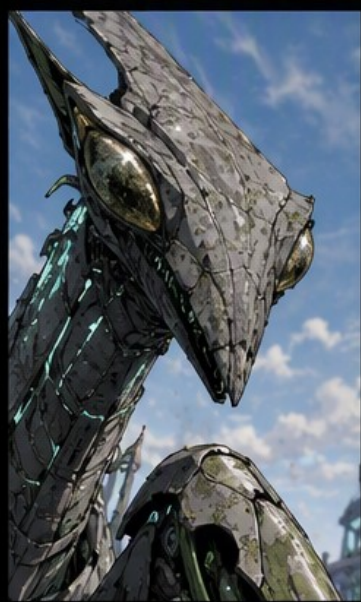


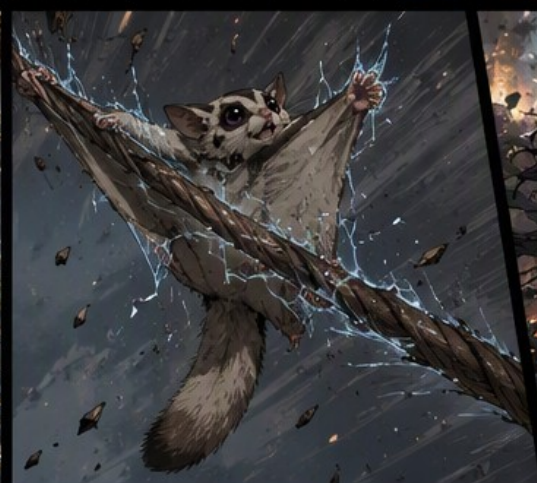
...BECOMES
LEGEND.



THE AURORA CITADEL.

CITY OF LIGHT.
CITY OF HARMONY.





THE AURORA CITADEL.

HEART OF THE FIRST LIGHT.
CROWN OF THE SKIES.

BUILT ON HOPE.
DEFENDED BY VOW.

AND ON THE EDGE OF
A TERRIFYING DROP.



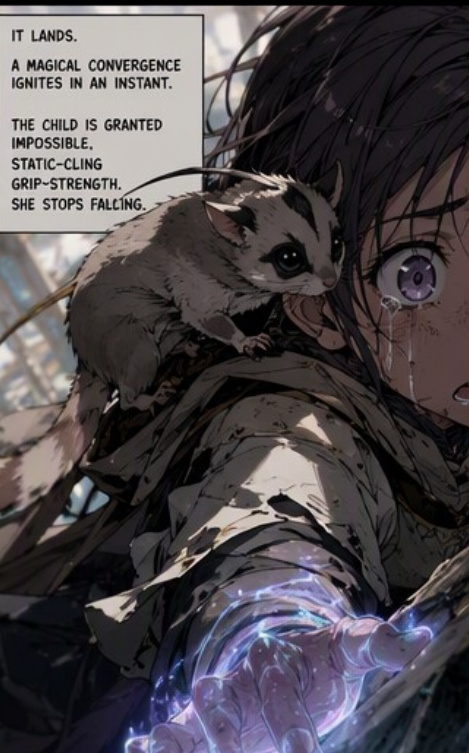
A WIND-SPOOL GLIDER.
A BACKGROUND-TEXTURE PRIMAL.
SIZE OF A SQUIRREL.
ZERO COMBAT UTILITY.
ALL INSTINCT AND STATIC.



SKITTISH.
FRAGILE.
TERRIFIED OF LOUD NOISES.

ITS GLIDING MEMBRANE
SECRETES A MICROSCOPIC,
STATIC-CLING RESIN—

ALLOWING IT TO STICK TO
SHEER SURFACES IN
HURRICANE WINDS.



IT LANDS.

A MAGICAL CONVERGENCE
IGNITES IN AN INSTANT.

THE CHILD IS GRANTED
IMPOSSIBLE,
STATIC-CLING
GRIP-STRENGTH.
SHE STOPS FALLING.



REACHING THE LEDGE.
SURVIVAL IS A
THREAD AWAY.



VANE.

TWENTY-NINE YEARS OLD.
SENTINEL. VOW-BEARER.

SHE HAS NEVER KNELT
IN DEFEAT.

TODAY, SHE DOESN'T
KNELL IN DEFEAT.

SHE BREAKS.

HER FACE IS A WAR
BETWEEN RELIEF AND
DEVASTATION—

THAT A TINY SQUIRREL
CHOSE A CHILD OVER HER
LIFETIME OF BLEEDING
FOR A CALLING.

THUD.

IT'S
JUST...

RANDOM.

THE SKYBREAK ARMADA.

A MASSIVE FLOATING CITY-STATE
FORCED TO FLEE ADVANCING
MILITARY DREADNOUGHTS.

A MILES-LONG TRAIN OF
LASHED-TOGETHER FLIGHT-BARGES,
MILITARY TRANSPORTS, CIVILIAN
CARGO SHIPS, AND HEAVY-TOW
CABLES SNAPPING IN THE
HURRICANE WINDS.

JURY-RIGGED INDUSTRIAL
SURVIVAL ON AN EPIC SCALE.

ATTEMPTS A DESPERATE CROSSING
INTO THE RAZOR-STREAM.

A LEGENDARY, PERMANENT
ATMOSPHERIC JETSTREAM.

A LOCALIZED, HYPER-VELOCITY
RIVER OF WIND THAT FLOWS
THROUGH THE UPPER ATMOSPHERE,
SHREDDING CONVENTIONAL AIRCRAFT.

THE AIR IS A HORIZONTAL RIVER OF
WHITE CLOUDS AND LIGHTNING.



THE RAZOR-STREAM.

A PERMANENT JET CURRENT
THAT HOWLS AT THE EDGE OF
THE WORLD. NOTHING MAN-
MADE CAN SURVIVE ITS FLOW.

AND STILL, THE
SKYBREAK ARMADA
CROSSES.

GUIDING THEM
THROUGH IT ALL...

PELL.

STEERSMAN.
CHEF. KEEPER OF
BISCUIT.

...WITH A PRIMAL
NAMED BISCUIT.

PANIC-INFLATED.
MAXIMUM BOUYANCY.
MAXIMUM GOOD BOY.

EASY,
BIG GUY...

JUST
HOLD THE
LINE.

LEFT
BARGE IS
DIPPING.

TWO
DEGREES
UP.

GOOD
BOY.

THAT'S
MY BOY.

YOU KEEP
THEM SAFE,

I'LL KEEP
THEM FED.

BISCUIT TAKES
THE HITS.

THE BARGES KEEP
MOVING.

THE PEOPLE
KEEP LIVING.

KRAAAANG!

THAT'S HOW
WE CROSS.

TOGETHER.

WHOOOOOOO-

THE RAZOR-STREAM.

A LEGENDARY, PERMANENT
ATMOSPHERIC JETSTREAM.

A LOCALIZED, HYPER-VELOCITY
RIVER OF WIND THAT FLOWS
THROUGH THE UPPER ATMOSPHERE,
SHREDDING CONVENTIONAL AIRCRAFT.

THE SKYBREAK ARMADA.
A MASSIVE FLOATING CITY-STATE
FORCED TO FLEE ADVANCING
MILITARY DREADNOUGHTS.

A MILES-LONG TRAIN OF LASHED-TOGETHER
FLIGHT-BARGES, MILITARY TRANSPORTS,
CIVILIAN CARGO SHIPS, AND HEAVY-TOW
CABLES SNAPPING IN THE HURRICANE
WINDS. JUNKY-RIGGED INDUSTRIAL
SURVIVAL ON AN EPIC SCALE.



IN THE HOWLING WHITE
CHAOS OF THE
RAZOR-STREAM JETSTREAM.

THE AIR IS FILLED WITH
TEARING CANVAS, SNAPPING
CABLES, AND LIGHTNING.

PASSING PEACEFULLY
DIRECTLY THROUGH THE
CENTER OF THE PANICKED
SKYBREAK ARMADA FLEET...

...IS THE STRATO-MANTA,
AN ARC-LEVEL ENVIRONMENTAL
THREAT PRIMAL.

IT IS COMPLETELY INDIFFERENT
TO HUMANITY.

TETHER
THREE'S
DRIFTING
HIGH!

HOSHI!
UP AND
LEFT!

HSSS!

THE STRATO-MANTA
BREATHES THE RAW
KINETIC ENERGY OF THE
JETSTREAM THROUGH
GILL-LIKE VENTS.

ROGUE ARTILLERY SHELLS
BOUNCE HARMLESSLY OFF ITS
MASSIVE, CARTILAGINOUS BACK.

FLYING FRANTICALLY
AROUND THE MASSIVE CREATURE
TO KEEP THE TETHER LINES
OF THE BARGES FROM GETTING
TANGLED ON ITS WING-SPARS...

17 YEARS OLD.
SKYBREAKER.
GLIDER PILOT.
TETHER-WRANGLER.

...IS MIZUKI.

IF IT CAN BE FLOWN,
I CAN KEEP IT IN THE AIR.

KRA-THOOM!

A BREATHTAKING
SET-PIECE OF
SCALE-VS-ENVIRONMENT
VERTIGO.

HA!

WIIHOOSH!

DEEP INSIDE THE HOWLING
WHITE CHAOS OF
THE RAZOR-STREAM.

A LEGENDARY, PERMANENT
ATMOSPHERIC JETSTREAM.
A LOCALIZED, HYPER-VELOCITY
RIVER OF WIND THAT FLOWS
THROUGH THE UPPER ATMOSPHERE,
SHREDDING CONVENTIONAL AIRCRAFT.

THE MASSIVE SILHOUETTE OF
THE STRATO-MANTA.
AN ARC-LEVEL ENVIRONMENTAL
THREAT PRIMAL.

THE SIZE OF A COMMERCIAL AIRLINER
(WINGSPAN OF 200 FEET).
A MASSIVE, WILD APEX-CREATURE.

IT BREATHES RAW KINETIC ENERGY
THROUGH GILL-LIKE VENTS.
COMPLETELY INDIFFERENT
TO HUMANITY.

FWOOOOSH!

THE SKYBREAK ARMADA.
A MASSIVE FLOATING CITY-STATE
FORCED TO FLEE ADVANCING
MILITARY DREADNOUGHTS.

A MILES-LONG TRAIN OF
LASHED-TOGETHER FLIGHT-BARGES,
MILITARY TRANSPORTS, CIVILIAN
CARGO SHIPS, AND HEAVY-TOW
CABLES SNAPPING IN THE
HURRICANE WINDS.

JURY-RIGGED INDUSTRIAL
SURVIVAL ON AN EPIC SCALE.

STRAY ROGUE ARTILLERY SHELLS
BOUNCE USELESSLY OFF ITS
MASSIVE CARTILAGINOUS BACK.

PULL UP!
GO OVER IT,
NOT UNDER!

MIZUKI

17 YEARS OLD.
GLIDER MECHANIC.
SKYBREAKER.

RESTLESS.
RECKLESS.
EXCEPTIONAL.

SHE DOESN'T JUST
RIDE THE STORM—
SHE READS IT.

HER GLIDER ISN'T
JUST A MACHINE.
IT'S AN EXTENSION
OF HER INSTINCT.

HOSHI

STRATO-LYNX.
KINETIC COMPANION.

CLOUD-WHITE MANE
CRACKLES WITH
STATIC.

BUILT FOR SPEED.
BUILT FOR THE
UPDRAFT.

HIS CLAWS GRIP.
HIS INSTINCTS
GUIDE.

TOGETHER,
THEY DON'T JUST
SURVIVE THE RAZOR-
STREAM—
THEY DANCE IN IT.

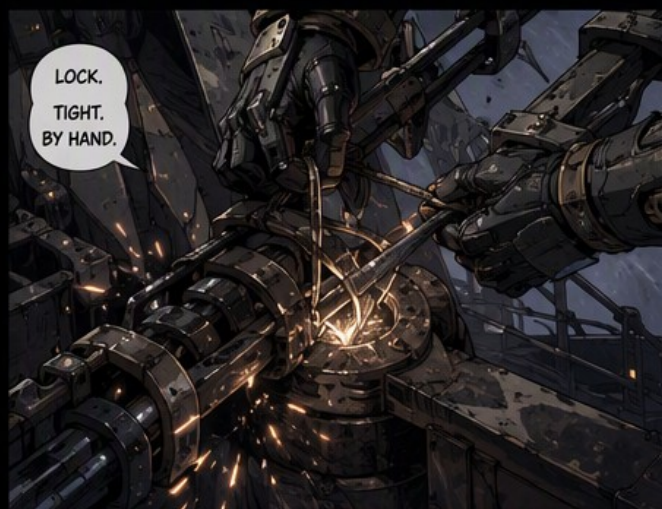


THE RAZOR-STREAM.

A PERMANENT ATMOSPHERIC JET-STREAM.
A HYPER-VELOCITY RIVER OF WIND THAT
FLOWS THROUGH THE UPPER ATMOSPHERE,
SHREDDING CONVENTIONAL AIRCRAFT.
ONLY THE HEAVY CAN RIDE IT.



THE HEAVY-TOW CABLE SNAPS.
TWO BARGES.
ONE HUNDRED TWENTY METERS APART.
THOUSANDS OF LIVES IN BETWEEN.



THE CALM, CLEAR
SKIES ON THE FAR SIDE
OF THE RAZOR-STREAM.

THE BRUTAL JETSTREAM
ACTS AS A PERMANENT WALL,
PREVENTING THE ROGUE
MILITARY DREADNOUGHTS
FROM FOLLOWING THE FLEET
ANY FURTHER.

THE BATTERED, SMOKING,
BUT SURVIVING BARGES OF
THE SKYBREAK ARMADA
SAIL PEACEFULLY INTO THE
CLEAR BLUE SKY...

...HAVING SUCCESSFULLY
CROSSED THE JETSTREAM
TO ESTABLISH A NEW,
POLITICALLY INDEPENDENT
FLOATING NATION.



WE
MADE IT.

AYE.
WE MADE IT.

YEAH...

WE MADE
IT.

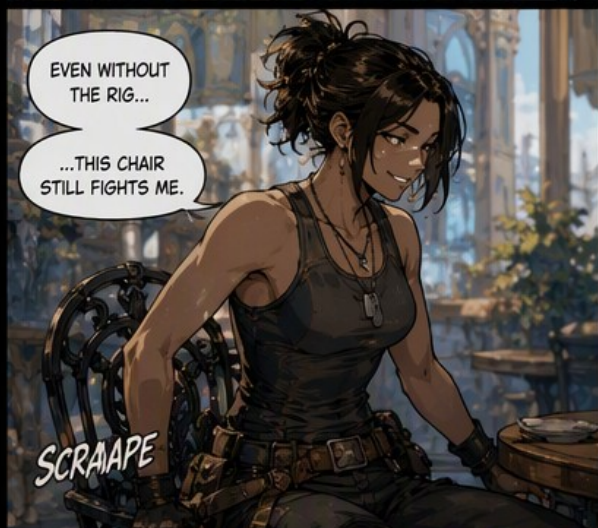
NOT BY
FATE.

BY GRIT.

WELCOME TO OUR SKY.



THE AURORA CITADEL
WATERSIDE MARKET



NO ALARM. NO FIRE.
NO WEIGHT ON OUR BACKS.
JUST TEA. JUST BREATH.
JUST US.



VANE
HUMAN
TACTICAL LEAD



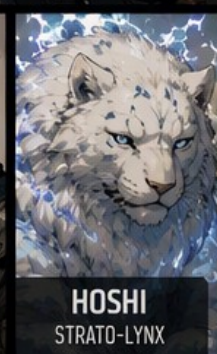
PELL
HUMAN
CARGO CHIEF



MIZUKI
HUMAN
GLIDER PILOT



TOBIAH
HUMAN
SURVEYOR



HOSHI
STRATO-LYNX



KESSEN
RIDGE-MANTIS



BISCUIT
PRIMAL